

Espresso Popsicles

A frozen vanilla-latte on a stick — premium coffee popsicles sold as a high-margin summer add-on for coffee shops (and a standalone market/DTC product). Espresso + milk + cream + sweetener, frozen in cheap sleeves. The drink a cafe already makes, in the format that sells when hot coffee doesn't.

The Insight

Coffee shops own everything this needs — an espresso machine, milk, cream, syrups, a freezer, and daily foot traffic — yet almost none sell a frozen coffee pop. It's near-zero marginal cost, it counters the summer slump (when hot-drink sales dip), and it photographs like a treat, not a beverage. The whole product is "your iced latte that doesn't water down."

The Product

Espresso popsicles: a few shots of espresso + 3 parts whole milk + 1 part heavy cream + sweetener (vanilla syrup = vanilla-latte flavor). For premium creamy texture, add corn syrup + sweetened condensed milk (less icy). Freeze overnight in popsicle sleeves. Line extensions: mocha, caramel, oat-milk/vegan, affogato dip, protein-coffee pop, boozy espresso-martini pop for events.

US Market & Competitors

- **\$63B global pop/ice-cream-bar market** (2025); artisan pops sell **\$4–8** each. The **coffee-flavor pop segment is small but fast-growing** (~\$0.15B → ~\$0.4B by 2035) — adult-leaning, under-served.
- **White space:** gourmet pop brands chase fruit/dessert flavors; **coffee is wide open**, and *no one is selling the "cafe upsell" angle*.
- **Buyers:** coffee-shop customers (impulse upsell), farmers markets, offices, events, and DTC freezer-pack shipping.
- **Edge:** lowest-friction entry of any food product — an existing cafe can launch tomorrow with zero new core ingredients.

China Import Sourcing (the cheap inputs)

- **Disposable popsicle sleeve bags:** custom-printed, heat-seal, food-grade on Alibaba/Global Sources — bulk MOQs (5,000–20,000) at pennies each → your branded sleeve is nearly free advertising.
- **Popsicle molds/racks, sticks, a small blast/chest freezer, branded display** all sourceable direct from China at a fraction of restaurant-supply prices. Add ~20–35% over FOB for freight + duty (note 2025 packaging tariffs — compare landed vs domestic).
- **Coffee/dairy:** source locally for freshness; the imported piece is packaging + equipment.

Startup Cost & Unit Economics

- **Cafe add-on: under \$500** — sleeves, a mold rack, a corner of the existing freezer. No new staff, no new core ingredients.
- **Standalone cart/DTC:** \$3,000–\$25,000 (chest freezer, branding, permits, cart).
- **Per pop:** espresso + milk/cream + sweetener ≈ \$0.40–\$0.75 + sleeve \$0.05–\$0.10. **COGS ≈ \$0.50–\$0.85.**
- **Price:** \$4–\$6 (cafe) / \$5–\$8 (gourmet/market). **Gross margin 85%+ — and for a cafe it's almost pure incremental profit.**

Revenue Potential

A single cafe selling 40–80 pops/day in summer at ~\$5 = **\$200–\$400/day in near-pure-margin add-on revenue** with no new core cost. Standalone: a market cart at 100–150/day. Scale via wholesaling sleeves+recipe to other cafes, multi-flavor DTC freezer packs, and event/catering (espresso-martini pops).

Go-To-Market

1. **Content-first:** the "frozen latte on a stick" reveal + the recipe hook (this exact reel format performs).
2. **Sell to cafes, not just consumers:** offer existing coffee shops a turnkey recipe + branded sleeves (you become their supplier).
3. **Own summer:** launch when hot-coffee sales dip; position as the seasonal money-maker.
4. **Flavor ladder:** vanilla latte → mocha/caramel/oat → boozy espresso-martini pops for events.

30 / 60 / 90-Day Launch

- **30:** perfect the recipe + texture (corn syrup/condensed-milk ratio); order branded sleeves; test sell at one cafe or market; film everything.
- **60:** cottage-food/commercial permit; build the content engine; sign 1–2 cafes as wholesale accounts or lock a cart spot.
- **90:** launch 3 flavors; add DTC freezer-pack shipping or a second cafe account; line up event/catering (espresso-martini pops).

Risks

- **Cold chain / melt** → chest freezer + insulated handoff; sell at point of traffic.
- **Seasonality** → it's a feature (summer upsell); add mocha/affogato + events for shoulder seasons.
- **Texture (iciness)** → the cream + corn syrup + condensed-milk ratio fixes it; standardize the recipe.
- **Permits** → start cottage-food / sell through a licensed cafe, scale to commercial kitchen.